CHALLENGE BRIEF · HACKTHEBURGH 2026 · 7–8 NOVEMBER · SET BY INSTALILY

The Agentic IDE Challenge

Build the coding assistant that knows who it's talking to.

01 The challenge

AI coding agents treat everyone the same. However, a student on their first day needs someone patient: someone who explains how they got there, lets them try, and checks that they followed. A senior engineer in a hurry wants the smallest correct change and no lecture. Most people sit somewhere in between, and each of them works and learns differently.

The task is to build an agentic IDE: an AI agent inside an editor that helps people debug, refactor and build real software, and adjusts to whoever is using it. That includes what it says, how much it explains, whether it acts or asks first, and how it teaches. How you do it is up to you.

02 What we're looking for

- **It works on real code.** It finds the actual cause, makes fixes that hold up, and is honest about what it did.
- **It reads people.** It works out who it's helping and adapts without being told.
- **It's built for someone.** Besides a beginner and an engineer, pick one more persona to design for. Tell us who, why and how.
- **It's yours.** Start from an open-source project or your own code, for both the editor and the agent. We score what you add.

03 How we judge

THE MINIMUM BAR	Your agent has to run headless with one command, `agent`. On a project you haven't seen, it must cleanly fix every one of a set of simple bugs. Teams that don't clear the bar aren't ranked.
AUTOMATED TESTS	Once submissions close, we put every agent through the same conversations, on unseen projects, with simulated users you won't see coming. Tests check anything code can check, like whether a bug is really fixed. An AI judge assesses how the agent treated the user, and our team reviews anything it's unsure about.
OUR REVIEWERS	Four InstaLILY engineers will come to your table. Show us what you built, then we try it ourselves and look at how it's built. That visit is your demo. We're judging the experience, your chosen persona and how well you served them, how much thought you put into your users, and the quality of your engineering.
THE FINAL	The three strongest teams present to everyone before we announce the winners.

04 What you get

- A private team repo with a starter agent, a Dockerfile, the manifest and our team kit
- The same environment we judge in, to run locally
- Gemini models through our gateway, with a US$50 development key per team
- The contract: all the technical details in one place

05 Prizes

1ST PLACE	A fast-track interview at InstaLILY and Sony WH-1000XM5 headphones for each team member
2ND PLACE	A Logitech MX Master 3S mouse for each team member
EVERY TEAM	Feedback from four InstaLILY engineers

06 Agenda

SAT 7 NOV	Hacking starts. You get your repo, your key and the contract
SUN 8 NOV · 12:00	Submissions close. We take `main` as it stands
12:30	Judging. Our reviewers visit every team
~13:30	The three finalists present
15:00	Closing ceremony and results

07 The rules in short

- Everything you submit must be on `main` in your team repo by 12:00 on Sunday.
- List every open-source project you built on, in your README and your manifest.
- Keep your key private. Don’t share it or put it anywhere public.

QUESTIONS DURING THE EVENT

Find any of our InstaLILY technical representatives at the InstaLILY table.

08 The Agent Contract

Access the agent contract here.